## Introduction and concepts in community health

Goal: Give overview of community health

Specific objectives:

- Define the key concepts and terms used in community health
- Explain determinants of health
- Describe community entry process

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- **Community** - a group of people who share some important feature of their lives and use some common agencies and institutions. Community is a specific group of people, often living in a defined geographical area, who share a common culture, values and norms and are arranged in a social structure according to relationships that the community has developed over a period of time.

- **Health** - a balanced state of well-being resulting from harmonious interactions of body, mind, and spirit."

- **Community health -** is defined by meeting the needs of a community by identifying problems and managing interactions within the community

- **Population** – a group of people living in a geographical setting in a period of time. Population can be described in terms of:
  - Cohort – group of people born in same period. They grow together in same age group
  - Risk group - Some population groups are at considerably higher risk of contracting disease than others. These include infants, children under five years of age, pregnant women, patients with HIV/AIDS, as well as non-immune migrants, mobile populations and travellers.
  - Density – is the number of people living in a square kilometer

- **Needs for health services** – Health services such as immunization, examination, treatment etc. are basic needs of every individual, family, community or entire population.

- **Demand for health services -** Every individual, family, community or entire population has a right to demand for essential and quality health services.

- **Primary health care** – Are interventions that focus on the individual or family. Are essential health services such as immunization, health education, nutrition and food supply, treatment and control of minor illnesses etc.

- **Risk of diseases –** Exposure to a disease. Some risk exposures are drug and alcohol consumption, immune-suppression etc.

**Aims -** improving the health of a community range from improving access to medical care to public health communications campaigns. The aims of community health are:

- To bring essential health services closer to the community members
- Empower community members to initiate, implement and own activities promoting their health

**Determinants of health**

- Economic determinants including income, employment and working conditions;

- Social determinants including social support, safety in the home and community, participation in civic activities and healthy child development; education and literacy
- Physical environmental determinants including the state of the natural environment, the presence of environmental tobacco smoke, availability of transportation and affordable and adequate housing; and
- Other determinants such as personal health practices, health services and biology and genetic endowment.

**Determinants of community health**

- *Community development* - The community development process is based on the philosophical belief that people and communities are entitled to have control over factors that affect their lives

- *Group* **-** People who interact and share a common purpose or purposes. There is no clear distinction between a group and a community except that groups tend to have fewer members than a community

- *Community health standards* - Promoting health; Building individual and community capacity through engagement and participation; Building relationships and ownership; Facilitating access and equity; Demonstrating professional responsibility, accountability and sustainability.

- *Community Engagement* **-** is the process of working collaboratively with and through groups of people affiliated by geographic proximity, special interest, or similar situations to address issues affecting the well-being of those people. It is a powerful vehicle for bringing about environmental and behavioral changes that will improve the health of the community and its members. It often involves partnerships and coalitions that help mobilize resources and influence systems, change relationships among partners, and serve as catalysts for changing policies, programs, and practices

- *Cultural Influence* **-** Health behaviors are influenced directly by elements of one's culture. As a result, social norms and other elements of community culture provide a potential tool for disease prevention and health promotion. Culture involves "the integrated pattern of human knowledge, belief, behavior, and material traits characteristic of a social group". An individual's culture influences his or her attitude toward various health issues, including perceptions of what is and is not a health problem, methods of disease prevention, treatments for illness, and use of health providers.

- *Community Participation* **-** Concepts concerning community participation offer one set of explanations as to why the process of community engagement might be useful in addressing the physical, interpersonal, and cultural aspects of individuals' environments.

- *Community Empowerment* **-** Mobilizing and organizing individuals, grass-roots and community-based organizations, and institutions, and enabling them to take action, influence, and make decisions on critical issues. It is important to note, however, that no external entity should assume that it can bestow on a community the power to act in its own self-interest. Empowerment takes place at three levels:
    - Individual,
    - Organizational or group, and
    - Community levels.

- *Capacity Building* - Another set of organizing concepts that can help guide approaches to effective engagement involves the process of capacity building. Individuals and organizations can gain control and influence and become players and partners in community health decision-making and action, they may need resources, knowledge, and skills above and beyond those they already bring to a particular problem

- *Community Organization* - A "process by which community groups are helped to identify common problems or goals, mobilize resources, and in other ways develop and implement strategies for reaching goals they have set

**Community health elements are:**

- Promotion of healthful living
- Prevention of health problems
- Treatment of disorders
- Rehabilitation
- Evaluation and
- Research

**Community health services are:**

- Child health services ( Immunization and Growth monitoring)
- Maternal services (Family planning, Antenatal, Postnatal, Health education)
- Treatment of minor illnesses
- Health promotion
- Referrals and follow up

**Community health standards**

- Engagement
- Participation
- Ownership
- Sustainability

**Community entry**

- Refers to the process of initiating, nurturing and sustaining a desirable relationship with the purpose of securing and sustaining the community's interest in al aspect of a programme.
- The process, principles and techniques of community mobilisation and participation. This involves recognizing the community its leadership and people and adopting the most appropriate process in meeting, interacting and working with them.
- Process involve:
  - Knock and enter upon response.
  - First greet chief and elders. Introduce yourself to the chief elders and other local leaders.
  - Inform them of your work with them.
  - Ask for their permission and advice and state your mission e.g. getting information about the village or introduction of new health programme.
  - Thank them for their co-operation.
  - Identify contact persons

**Millennium Development Goals**

The Millennium Development Goals (MDGs) are eight international development goals that were established following the Millennium Summit of the United Nations in 2000, following the adoption of the United Nations Millennium Declaration. All 189 United Nations member states at the time (there are 193 currently) and at least 23 international organizations committed to help achieve the following Millennium Development Goals by 2015:

1. To eradicate extreme poverty and hunger
2. To achieve universal primary education
3. To promote gender equality and empower women
4. To reduce child mortality
5. To improve maternal health
6. To combat HIV/AIDS, malaria, and other diseases
7. To ensure environmental sustainability
8. To develop a global partnership for development

**Problem solving in community medicine**

- What is a problem?
  - Problems are *opportunities* to make some good things happen. If it weren't for problems, what would be our motivation to create change?
  - Problems are also *challenges*. They call upon the best of our abilities, and ask us to go beyond what we thought we could do. They make life interesting, and, at least sometimes, fun. Without problems, life could be pretty boring.

- **Problem solving process:**

  **Step 1 - Problem Definition**

  Before you are ready to take any steps to solve the problem, you first have to be sure that you are clear about what the problem really is. It can be easy to get distracted by solving a different problem than what is actually causing distress if it is easier than dealing with the real problem. This step involves thinking about the following questions:
  - How is the current situation different from what I actually want it to be?
  - What do I actually want, or how do I actually want things to be?
  - What is preventing me from achieving my goals, or from things being the way I want them to be?

  **Step 2 – Problem Analysis**

  Once you have defined the problem, you need to think about it from different perspectives to insure that you understand all the dimensions of the problem.
  The following questions can be useful to help you analyze the problem.
  1. How is this problem affecting me?
  2. How is this problem affecting other people?
  3. Who else is experiencing this problem?
  4. How do other people deal with this problem?

  **STEP 3 – Establish your goals**

  Once you have looked at the problem from different perspectives, you can decide what you want to achieve and establish your goals. You need to answer the very specific question – "What is my immediate goal?"
  Examples:
  - Improve my time management skills
  - Complete assignments on time

- Improve my grades

**STEP 4 – Generate possible solutions**

- During this stage the goal is to generate as many possible solutions as you can.
- Do not worry about whether or not they are realistic, practical, or effective.
- Be sure to write down all the possibilities you generate so that you can approach this task systematically.

**STEP 5 – Analyze the solutions**

During this stage, you will examine each alternative and write down both the advantages and disadvantages to each. Some considerations to keep in mind include:

- Is it relevant to my situation?
- Is it realistic?
- Is it manageable?
- What are the consequences – both good and bad?
- What is the likelihood that it is going to help me reach my goal?

**STEP 6 - Implementation**

The last step is to implement the solution you have chosen. This step involves identification of all the steps necessary to implement it, and also on-going monitoring of the effectiveness of the solution to make sure that it actually solved the problem. During this stage of the process, ask yourself the following questions:

1. How effective is the solution?
2. Did it achieve what I wanted?
3. What consequences (good and bad) did it have in my situation?

**Factors Contributing to the Success of Community Engagement Efforts**

- Environmental
- History of collaboration or cooperation in the community
- Membership - Mutual respect, self-interest, understanding, and trust
- Process/Structure - Members feel ownership —share stake in both process and outcome
- Every level in each organization in collaborating groups participates in decision-making
- Flexibility of collaborating group
- Clarity of roles and guidelines
- Communication - Open and frequent interaction, information, and discussion; Informal and formal channels of communications
- Purpose - Goals clear and realistic to all partners; Shared vision;
- Resources - Sufficient funds; Skilled convener